south, in states where there is evidence to show dynastic politics could get you a foot in the door. In Telangana, thus, the BJP picked for vice-president D.K. Aruna—a former Congress minister in united Andhra Pradesh who has political pedigree both on her paternal and her in-laws' side. Aruna, on her part, has helped the party make inroads in rural Telangana. In Andhra, the party has turned to former Union minister D. Purandeswari Devi, daughter of the late CM and icon N.T. Rama Rao. She has been made a national general secretary, and is now party in-charge of Odisha.

There is also tactical deployment. Nadda explains: "In Goa, Deviya Rane was fielded to keep her father-in-law Pratapsingh Rane out of the contest. Similarly, in UP, we experimented with a greenhorn dynast, Riya Shakya, from Bidhuna after her father Vinay Shakya, our sitting MLA, went over to the SP just before elections. She narrowly lost." But it can backfire in a more serious way too. In many cases where the 'no dynasty' rule was waived, especially with imports, a top BJP source concedes it led to resentment within the party. Contrary to Modi's words, the party has nuanced its position and settled on a horses-for-courses kind of pragmatism. BJP sources now say every seat is analysed on a case-by-case basis, and there is no blanket ban on dynasts. The rule in the selection process, apparently, is "merit and performance"; family connections are a minor concern.

That's good news for second-generation leaders. In MP, the children of BJP heavyweights are already poised for growth. Over 10 of them are active in politics, including Union minister Narendra Tomar's son Devendra and home minister Narottam Mishra's son Sukarn. CM Shivraj Chouhan's son Kartikey and Jyotiraditya Scindia's son Mahanaryaman also seem to be settling into public life. Rajasthan, Gujarat, Maharashtra, J&K...all have BJP politicians seeking positions for their wards. Even Nadda's son Harish has been canvassing in the Bilaspur segment in Himachal Pradesh, though he maintains there is only "one person in politics" in the family.

The party also does not lack advocates of dynasticism, who say it has worked for many parties in India. "You have hard-working kinsfolk of politicians: should they join some other party?" asks a leader in Delhi. Since the BJP is also pursuing the 75 cutoff age in electoral politics, it has got several leaders grooming their heirs to take forward the legacy. As one BJP leader puts it succinctly, "Why would I make the extra effort to nurture the constituency if I can't pass on my legacy?" That this is where unequal distribution of power is born—and that "it breeds corruption", as Modi said—are facts that aren't always remembered.

ANI



WELCOME WAGON Goa CM Pramod Sawant (third from left) with Michael Lobo (second from right) and other Congress leaders who joined the BJP on Sept. 14

Of course, the chief purpose of that high rhetoric is to target the BJP's established political opponents. For, whichever way you cast your eye at the non-BJP landscape, dynasty stares back at you—from the Gandhi family to the Abdullahs and Muftis in Kashmir, down to the Karunanidhi family in Tamil Nadu. That narrative is useful. In 2019, 45 million first-timers voted in the general election; in 2024, the number is expected to cross 50 million. "There is growing disenchantment with entrenched dynasties that consider power an entitlement," says a political strategist with a BJP think-tank. "Modi's idea of reducing the number of dynasties and giving space to new faces does make sense in this scenario."

The party, though, is finding it problematic to put the plan into action. A recent study published by IndiaSpend found that since 1999, the Congress has had 36 dynastic MPs elected to the Lok Sabha; the BJP wasn't far behind with 31 MPs. But Rahul Verma, a fellow at the New Delhi-based think-tank Centre for Policy Research, points out a crucial difference: "In the Congress as well as many regional parties, the organisation is controlled by a single family. That's not the case in the BJP," he says.

Yet, it is not easy for the BJP to build a decisive narrative here. Many of its allies are dynasts—such as the Jannayak Janta Party led by fourth-generation politician Dushyant Chautala in Haryana, and Apna Dal led by Anupriya Patel, daughter of party founder Sone Lal Patel, in UP. After the exit of Nitish Kumar's JD(U) from the NDA, the BJP has approached Chirag Paswan in Bihar to reclaim father Ram Vilas Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party legacy. How that will pan out is uncertain seeing how Modi has inducted Chirag's rebel uncle, Pashupati Paras, in the Union cabinet.

Talking of rebels, the party's latest ally, Shiv Sena leader and Maharashtra CM Eknath Shinde, is building his own dynasty with son Shrikant Shinde already an MP from Kalyan. The party is also cosying up to the TDP, controlled by Chandrababu Naidu's family, in Andhra Pradesh. The BJP will justify all this with the means-serving-the-ends argument, but then perhaps it's time to let the mask slide, and embrace a culture that has paid it dividends across the country. ■